

Esox lucius

Northern pike



Length Up to 4¼ ft (1.3 m)
Weight Up to 75 lb (34 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location North America, Europe, Asia



This powerfully built predator is one of only a few freshwater fish to have a circumpolar distribution across the whole of the northern hemisphere. The northern pike is superbly camouflaged with light markings on its body. Like its close relative, the muskellunge (see below), it has a long head with a shovel-like snout, a large, slightly forked tail, and a single dorsal fin. Pike generally spawn during the day, in early spring after the ice has melted. They initially

spawn as a pair, but either the male or the female may take on a new partner later. While courting, the male prods the female on her head and pectoral fins with his snout. Female northern pikes grow faster and larger than the males.

STEALTHY HUNTER

The single dorsal fin of the northern pike, set well back near its tail, allows it to approach prey on the surface of lakes without making any warning ripples.

SILENT AMBUSH



The well-camouflaged northern pike hunts by lying in wait among waterweeds, bursting out of cover the instant its prey comes within range. It feeds mainly on other fishes, but also eats insects, frogs, and crayfishes, as well as animals swimming on the surface, such as water voles and young waterfowl.



Esox masquinongy

Muskellunge



Length Up to 6 ft (1.8 m)
Weight Up to 99 lb (45 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location E. North America



putting up a ferocious fight when hooked. In common with other pikes, it has a very large mouth armed with sharp teeth, a sloping forehead and beaklike jaws, and a torpedo-shaped body, which can accelerate very rapidly with a sudden flick of the tail. It can be identified by the lack of scales on the lower cheeks and gill covers (opercula). A lie-in-wait predator, it ambushes and feeds on animals as large as muskrats, catching its prey sideways in its mouth, before turning them around and swallowing them head-first. Muskellunges spawn over vegetation in mid-spring, after the ice

has melted. A female may pair with more than one male and can lay more than 250,000 eggs in a single season. This fish is found in heavily vegetated lakes and rivers, generally in warmer waters than those inhabited by northern pikes (see above), although the 2 fishes may be found in the same habitat and will occasionally even interbreed. The resulting hybrids are a robust breed with strongly barred markings. The male hybrid is sterile but females are often fertile. The muskellunge is more sensitive to habitat changes than the northern pike, so its numbers decline first should any change occur.

Dallia pectoralis

Alaska blackfish



Length Up to 13 in (33 cm)
Weight Up to 13 oz (375 g)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location N.E. Asia, N.W. North America



The Alaska blackfish belongs to the mudminnow family—a group of fishes that can survive in very cold and stagnant water by gulping mouthfuls of air. They can even survive being partly frozen in the ice for periods of several weeks. This species has a slender body with rounded fins, a blunt head, and a large mouth with a protruding lower jaw. It is dark green or mottled brown, and the males develop a red outline to their fins during the breeding season. This slow-moving fish feeds on insect larvae, snails, and smaller fishes, which it ambushes and hunts with a darting movement.



Stenodus nelma

Sheefish



Length At least 5 ft (1.5 m)
Weight 62–88 lb (28–40 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

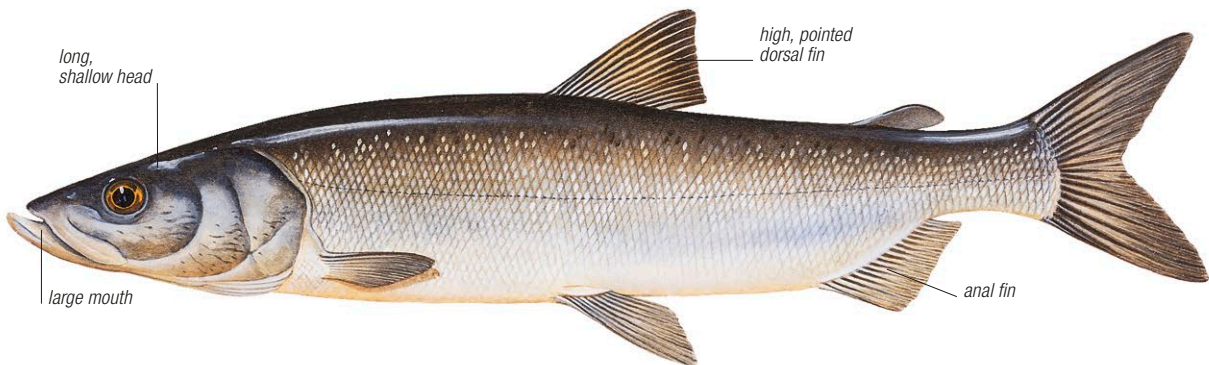
Location North Pacific, N.W. North America, E. Europe to N.E. Asia



in 2 different ways: some—for example in Canada's Great Slave Lake—are permanent freshwater fishes, which remain in their home range to breed, but most overwinter in brackish water or estuaries, and move upriver in

spring. They remain there until autumn, when they spawn. The female is accompanied by one or 2 males during spawning bouts, which take place between dusk and nighttime, and probably occur only every third

or fourth year. She lays between 130,000 and 400,000 eggs. Although it is valued as a sport fish, the sheefish is more important in commercial fisheries in Canada, Alaska, and Siberia, where it is commonly found.



This large member of the salmon family has a long, broad, and shallow head and a large mouth with very fine teeth. As an adult, it feeds mainly on other fishes, but its young eat insect larvae and planktonic animals. Sheefishes live